No.40 Showing the Flag

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Showing the Flag analysis

In the exam, you will be asked to **answer one question from two options**. Both questions will be on a different text from the selection of ten texts in Stories of Ourselves Volume 2.

Because there are so many text options, make sure you read through the exam instructions carefully, and look for the questions on Stories of Ourselves.

The following guide to Showing the Flag by Jane Gardam contains:

- Plot summary
- Themes, ideas and perspectives
- Writer's methods
- Key quotations

Plot summary of Showing the Flag

Jane Gardam's short story Showing the Flag depicts a young teenage boy, Philip, leaving his mother, Gwen, and his English home to travel to France. His mother is sad to see him go again (she says he has been going to boarding schools since he was six years old). Gwen's friend Miss Pym reminds her that this is the "custom" in England and children must learn to "endure".

Philip waves goodbye and spends some time looking at the seagulls as he hangs over the ship's railings. He starts thinking about food, and what it will be like in France, and then about the **Union Jack** flag that he has in a little tin. His mother has packed him the small flag to pin to his coat when he arrives in France. This is to identify him to Major Foster, a French-Canadian, who is to meet Philip when he arrives. Philip wants to look at the flag, so he takes it out of the tin, but it blows away.

Once in France, Philip finds himself in a crowd of French-speaking people on the quay. In the rush, someone tries to steal his suitcase but he is able to kick him off.

Finally, on the train, he finds a seat, has to defend his suitcase from another "ruffian", and then looks out the window at the strange unfamiliar landscape. He notices the people outside

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

He begins to worry about how Major Foster will find him if he has not got the flag on his coat. His thoughts turn to his mother (who always "kept everything right") and overheard comments from her friend Miss Pym. He remembers a night when Miss Pym was unkind to his father who had been singing drinking songs.

As Philip's anxiety grows, he begins to question his mother's love. He remembers that she was in "bed" during his father's funeral, and that she did not cry when Philip boarded the ship. He decides that she is "stupid" not to have sewn the flag onto his coat before he left, or to have packed him a spare one. When the people around him begin to eat, he finds the neatly packed sandwiches his mother has given him. He opens the packaging and finds a spare **Union Jack** flag with a loving note from his mother apologising for "fussing" over him.

Examiner Tips and Tricks

In order to answer the question in Section B of the CIE Literature in English Poetry and Prose Paper 1, it is best to have a thorough knowledge of the story's plot. You will need to be able to support your points with references from the story, and consider how themes and characters develop (or not).

Themes, ideas and perspectives in Showing the Flag

For top marks, you need to form a critical understanding of the text's themes and ideas. This is best when it includes personal judgements and evaluations of the themes, ideas, and perspectives of the text. Here are some of the key ideas you will need to understand in Jane Gardam's Showing the Flag.

What are the key themes in Showing the Flag?

Theme	Analysis

Family relationships	• Gardam illustrates misunderstandings between a teen boy and his mother, using irony to build sympathy for them both:
	  ○ Philip thinks his mother's "crying-and-laughing-together" means she is not sad to see him go
	  ○ Readers see a mother attempting to be strong:
	  ▪ She is in reality "laughing at her weakness"

	a spare flag in his packed sandwiches with a loving note
	• Philip's limited understanding of his parents and their relationship results in him doubting his mother's love:
	  ○ Miss Pym's **dialogue** reveals that Philip did not know his father well, and his mother, Gwen, "scarcely" saw him
	  ○ But Philip remembers her "not listening" to his father

Cultural identity	• Gardam's story raises themes about **patriotism**:
	  ○ The story's title refers to an **idiom** about naval ships
	  ○ Ships would proudly display the flag of their country of origin upon entering a foreign port
	  ○ The **Union Jack** is symbolic of Philip's British identity
	• The story reveals how Philip begins to notice differences between the French and the "English":
	  ○ He refers to the way the English "keep private their secret thoughts" in comparison to the "daring" French
	  ○ He implies this would minimise misunderstandings
	• Gardam raises questions about "the culture of the English middle class", illustrating how secrets lead to doubt:
	  ○ Philip's confusion arises as a result of his mother's attempts at being **stoic**: she is not "one to break"
	  ○ His memories of her "gone off to bed" for his father's funeral makes him think she did not care

Independence	• Gardam depicts barriers between Philip and his mother:
	  ○ He awkwardly kisses her goodbye with a "sliding away of the eyes", implying he is keen to leave
	• At first, the 13-year-old Philip is childlike, distracted by seagulls, and "scuffing his shoes like a two-year-old":
	  ○ His first thought is that he is "hungry"

Help me understand

	his mother's care:
	  ○ He imagines that his mother and Miss Pym are happy he is gone, that they "got rid of him together"
	• Gardam shows how Philip is determined to "manage" alone:
	  ○ He decides his mother is "stupid" and "wicked"
	  ○ He wards off thieves, plans to find work in France, and decides to make a flag to replace the lost one

Writer's methods in Showing the Flag

In her short story Showing the Flag, Jane Gardam raises questions about the emotional and psychological impact of a young boy's cultural identity as he leaves his mother for a new country.

Technique	Analysis

Omniscient narrator	• Gardam uses an omniscient narrator to show both the mother and the son's perspective so as to convey their different experiences:
	  ○ Philip's mother, Gwen, "can't bear" her son leaving her
	  ○ Philip is a little confused when he waves "in vain" at his "laughing" and "weeping" mother who is led away with "streaming cheeks"
	• The third-person narration creates pathos:
	  ○ Gardam introduces Philip sympathetically
	  ○ He has "big ears" and "immense suitcases", and his "father was dead"
	• Gardam's poignant stream of consciousness shows Philip's misunderstandings as a result of his innocence:
	  ○ He thinks: "She did not love him, want him, know him and she never had… She wanted him lost"

Symbolism	• Gardam uses the symbol of the **Union Jack** flag to represent Philip's British

	◦ Miss Pym suggests it is "rather a lot to expect of a Frenchman" to "wear the English flag", which alludes to **Anglo-French conflicts** ◦ Gardam may be alluding to national tensions, too, through Miss Pym's reference to the **Union Jack** as an "English" flag ◦ Gwen says that the "Fosters are French-Canadian" and that they're "very English", which alludes to Canada as a **British colony** • Philip's suitcase is symbolic of a young boy taking on an adult role: ◦ Travelling alone to France as a 13-year-old boy, his mother says that his suitcases are "nearly as big as he is" ◦ His mother's love is represented by the way she has packed his suitcase so carefully, and with love and expertise ◦ On his travels, Philip is forced to protect his suitcases from thieves, which represents his growing independence

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward essay responses that sensitively consider the writer's use of language, structure and form. This means you should explore how literary techniques convey meaning, reveal deeper ideas, and imply certain attitudes.

It is almost always worth discussing the writer's choice of perspective. Who is telling the story and what attitudes are revealed through the narration or inner monologue? Remember, the narrator is not the author. Authors create characters that will effectively deliver their themes or raise certain issues with which they are concerned. For instance, Jane Gardam reveals the thoughts of both a mother and son in her story so that she can raise themes about family relationships.

Showing the Flag key quotations

The mark scheme for the CIE IGCSE Literature in English Paper 1, Section B asks you to showcase your knowledge of the story in the question. To do this, you should refer to the text through references and quotations. You will not be required to

points.

The best way to revise quotations is in connection to a theme. Below you will find explanations and analysis of some key quotations from Jane Gardam's Showing the Flag, arranged by the following themes:

- **Family relationships**
- **Cultural identity**
- **Independence**

Family relationships

> **"He'd heard them saying in the kitchen that it was her being so perfect had killed his father, though goodness knows, thought Philip, what that meant" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- Philip thinks that his mother is to blame for his father's death because he heard "them" (perhaps Miss Pym and his mother's friends) say that she was involved
- He is not sure what they meant when they said his father died because his mother was "perfect"

Analysis

- Gardam shows a young boy's confusion about his parent's relationship, and his unresolved grief over his father's death
- Through Philip's vague memories, Gardam implies that his reserved English upbringing has left him with misunderstandings and doubt about his parents
- Gardam alludes to an imbalanced relationship between Gwen, Philip's mother, and his father, and, importantly, the way things have been hidden from Philip

> **"How stupid. How stupid of his mother. Why hadn't she sewed the Union Jack on his raincoat in the first place?" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- Philip is annoyed that he has lost the flag that will identify him to Major Foster when he arrives in Paris
- He thinks his mother should have thought to sew the flag on his coat instead of packing it in a tin

Analysis

- Gardam's **omniscient narrator** takes on Philip's voice to convey his emotional turmoil about leaving home:

- Gardam implies, though, that this is Philip's way to cope with his forced separation

Cultural identity

> **"Children — it's all renunciation. Having them is just learning to give them up" — Gwen**

Meaning and context

- Gwen, Philip's mother says that parenthood is all about abandoning children and learning to lose them
- She is upset that her son has spent so much of his childhood at boarding schools

Analysis

- Gardam presents the English "custom" of sending children to boarding school negatively by presenting a distressed mother who feels she is losing her son
- Gwen's distress about her son's constant absence is conveyed in short sentences
- Gwen's use of the word "renunciation" highlights her painful sense of resignation to English middle-class customs of sending children away, which Philip misinterprets as rejection

> **"I hope their French is not patriotic. If so there is very little point in Philip going" — Miss Pym**

Meaning and context

- Miss Pym makes a witty comment about the French-Canadians who are taking care of Philip in France:
  - Gwen says they are **patriotic** to France and England and are "very English"
- Miss Pym suggests that she hopes they are more "patriotic" to France, or their French may not be of good quality
- She says if Philip does not learn to speak French well, he may as well not go

Analysis

- Gardam highlights the English tradition of going to France, or sending one's children there, to learn the language, often an indication of status and class
- She **wryly** suggests that if the Fosters are too "English", they will not speak French very well, and this will make the trip pointless

Independence

> **"There is a point when every child sees through his parents" — Miss Pym**

Meaning and context

- Miss Pym warns Philip that he will one day understand his parents better and see them for who they really are

Analysis

- Gardam's character Miss Pym raises ideas about **feminism** and family tradition:
  - She is described as "plain-spoken", discusses "politics", and she tells Gwen she is "wasted now as a mere mother"
- While Philip dislikes her intensely, calling her "Stinkerpym", she speaks plainly to him

> **"Look at *Treasure Island*. You can get on without your mother" — Narrator**

Meaning and context

- Philip is determined to stay strong on his journey to France without his mother
- He reminds himself of young heroes in a children's story to encourage himself

Analysis

- Gardam's sympathetic portrayal of Philip reveals the complexities of growing up and finding independence
- **Ironically**, Philip looks to children's adventure stories as inspiration for how to manage as an adult in his new life alone

Sources

Wilmer, M (ed.), 2018, *Stories of Ourselves: Cambridge Assessment International Education Anthology of Stories in English Volume 2*, Cambridge University Press.

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